

As Menendez Soared, So Did The Suspicions

Prosecutors Circled for Years Before Charges

By NICHOLAS FANDOS

Robert Menendez’s education in political corruption came unusually early. In 1982, he turned against his mentor, Mayor William V. Musto of Union City, N.J., the popular leader of their gritty hometown.

Mr. Menendez took the witness stand and testified that city officials had pocketed kickbacks on construction projects, helping to put a man widely seen as his father figure behind bars. Mr. Menendez, then 28, wore a bullet-proof vest for a month.

The episode, which Mr. Menendez has used to cast himself as a gutsy Democratic reformer, helped fuel his remarkable rise from a Jersey tenement to the pinnacles of power in Washington as the state’s senior senator. The son of Cuban immigrants, Mr. Menendez broke barriers for Latinos and has used his perch as chairman of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee to influence presidents and prime ministers.

But those who have closely followed his career say the years he spent enmeshed in Mr. Musto’s machine also set the tone for another, more sinister undercurrent that now threatens to swallow it —



JEFFERSON SIEGEL FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Senator Robert Menendez and his wife, Nadine Arslanian.

one in which Mr. Menendez became a power broker himself whose own close ties to moneyed interests have repeatedly attracted the scrutiny of federal prosecutors.

Those two sides of his life collided on Wednesday in federal court in Manhattan, where Mr. Menendez, 69, surrendered to face his second bribery indictment in less than a decade.

The explosive charges, unveiled on Friday, accuse the senator and his wife of taking hundreds of thousands of dollars in bribes in exchange for helping increase U.S. assistance to Egypt and trying to throttle a pair of criminal investigations involving New Jersey businessmen. Inves-

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ERIN SCHAFF/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Brenda Valenzuela and her family attended a middle school walk-through before the first day of school in Helena, Mont., last month.

New E.U. Law Forces Big Tech To Police Truth

By STEVEN LEE MYERS

The Facebook page in Slovakia called Som z dediny, which means “I’m from the village,” trumpeted a debunked Russian claim last month that Ukraine’s president had secretly purchased a vacation home in Egypt under his mother-in-law’s name.

A post on Telegram — later recycled on Instagram and other sites — suggested that a parliamentary candidate in the country’s coming election had died from a Covid vaccine, though he remains very much alive. A far-right leader posted on Facebook a photograph of refugees in Slovakia doctored to include an African man brandishing a machete.

As Slovakia heads toward an election on Saturday, the country has been inundated with disinformation and other harmful content on social media sites. What is different now is a new European Union law that could force the world’s social media platforms to do more to fight it — or else face fines of up to 6 percent of a company’s revenue.

The law, the Digital Services Act, is intended to force social media giants to adopt new policies

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‘Make Sure You Duck Behind Your Backpack’

By ELI SASLOW

HELENA, Mont. — It was the beginning of another school year in America, and Brenda Valenzuela, 37, called her children into the living room to make sure they were prepared. Bella, 15, arrived with a stack of notebooks alphabetized by subject, pencils sorted by color and a binder that read: “High school — magical years!” Caleb, 11, came in wearing one sneaker, dragging a bag of football equipment and carrying a cell phone, to which he’d forgotten his password.

“What’s that smell?” Brenda asked him.

“This is the year I’m trying out cologne,” he said. “Too much?”

“Dude, way too much,” she said, and then she gestured for her children to sit down so they could go

over what had become the most critical part of their back-to-school routine.

“Keep in mind that the threat can come when you least expect it,” she told them, remembering how small the shooter had looked that October morning in 2015, how he smiled as he walked into the classroom, how he aimed for the teacher’s head, fired from point-blank range and then laughed.

“You have to turn on all of your senses,” she said, thinking about the way each gunshot had vibrated

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Sudden End to Long, Bloody Conflict

Fleeing Nagorno-Karabakh, which Azerbaijan seized from Armenia seemingly overnight. Page A6.

Sheriff Tapped Subpoena Power To Spy on His Married Girlfriend

By ILYSSA DALY and JERRY MITCHELL

BRANDON, Miss. — In 2014, Bryan Bailey, the sheriff of Rankin County, Miss., made what seemed like a series of routine requests of the local district attorney’s office.

He needed grand jury subpoenas, he said, to force the phone company to turn over records of calls and text messages for what he called a “confidential internal investigation.”

Sheriff Bailey scrawled a brief note on a subpoena form and gave it to a paralegal in the district attorney’s office. “Please keep this

confidential between you and I,” the note read. “Possible wrongdoing by school district employee.”

But his requests had nothing to do with alleged wrongdoing, or any criminal investigation, according to a previously undisclosed report obtained by The New York Times and the Mississippi Center for Investigative Reporting at Mississippi Today. Instead, Sheriff Bailey tapped into the power of a grand jury at least eight times over a year to spy on

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Blown Off Course, a Flock of North Americans Delights the U.K.

By DERRICK BRYSON TAYLOR

More than a dozen species of North American birds rarely seen in Britain and Ireland have been spotted along the countries’ western shores after being blown off their usual migration routes by remnants of Hurricane Lee and surviving the perilous journey across the Atlantic, experts said.

The arrival of warblers, vireos and other colorful birds last week has excited Britain’s twitching community — enthusiastic bird-watchers who will travel long distances to view new or unusual species. A sighting of a Canada warbler was the first recorded in Britain and similarly, a Blackburnian warbler was spotted in Ireland for the first time. Experts said twitchers should act fast if

A Storm Reroutes Birds Across the Atlantic

they want to see the North American arrivals, as the phenomenon will last just a few days longer.

Alexander Lees, an academic who specializes in biodiversity at Manchester Metropolitan University and the chairman of the British Ornithologists’ Union Records Committee, a group that maintains the official list of bird sightings in Britain, said on Tuesday that a series of storms had recently held up some bird migration in North America. When the birds decided to fly south for the winter, they were swept up in the

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A Less-Evil Twin

Antimatter is subject to the same gravitational force as its counterpart, an experiment at CERN shows. Few physicists are surprised.

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Heading Toward a Shutdown

With a deadline looming to fund the government, at least 10 hard-right Republicans have formed a wall of opposition to a stopgap bill.

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Met Opera’s Opening Bet

The music soars and the emotions are passionate in “Dead Man Walking,” part of the Met’s new focus on contemporary works, so why isn’t it riveting?

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ONLINE: DEBATE COVERAGE

Seven Hopefuls Take Stage

G.O.P. candidates faced off in California in the second presidential debate, while Donald J. Trump headed to Detroit. For the latest news, go to nytimes.com.

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Charles M. Blow

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